TOPIC 2 · PERSONALISATION, .RULES AND SKILLS FOR EXCEL
LAB 4 THEME · WORKBOOK .RULES

Lab 4 — Create and Test Workbook .Rules for Water Service Reporting

Maps to	LO2: distinguish account Personalisation, workbook .Rules and reusable Skills; configure, apply and verify each using water-service evidence.
Duration	35 minutes
Tools	Microsoft 365 Copilot in Excel · OneDrive
Mock data	data/Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx
Course	GenAI for Engineers · v2.2
Prompts	../../docs/prompts/index.html#lab-4

Goal

Turn Northstar's workbook conventions into a visible .Rules worksheet. Keep one rule per cell in column A, include a formula-driven reporting-date rule, test the output, and verify that the sheet travels with a copied workbook. A .Rules sheet is guidance for Copilot, not Excel formula enforcement or a security boundary.

What You Will Do

Turn Northstar's workbook conventions into a visible .Rules worksheet. Keep one rule per cell in column A, include a formula-driven reporting-date rule, test the output, and verify that the sheet travels with a copied workbook. A .Rules sheet is guidance for Copilot, not Excel formula enforcement or a security boundary.

What You Will Build

Northstar_Rules_Workbook.xlsx with visible .Rules column A, a checked Rules_Test output and a copied-workbook sharing check.

Prerequisites

- Microsoft 365 account with Copilot available in Word, Excel, PowerPoint and Outlook. Availability depends on the assigned licence and tenant settings; confirm access with the trainer before class.
- Desktop Excel on Windows or Mac is recommended; save working copies to your assigned OneDrive course folder with AutoSave on. Do not overwrite the supplied input.
- Download this whole lab folder. All files are synthetic; work-c027 is your own learner output folder.
- Lab 3 scope comparison; verified Lab1 clean source or supplied checkpoint.

Data note

Northstar Water Services is a fictional water-pipe maintenance and service company. All service hubs, staff and work orders are synthetic. Use the fixed reporting date 2026-09-30; missing facts remain UNKNOWN. Proposals do not change real assignments. Training email drafts are never sent.

Steps

Step 1. Open the clean workbook, save as Northstar_Rules_Workbook.xlsx and inspect Control. In Copilot use Add work content > Create workbook rules if offered; otherwise insert a sheet manually and rename it exactly .Rules, including the leading dot. Keep it visible. Rules are fully supported only in English.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - CHAT ONLY:
Inspect this Northstar workbook. Identify the source table, fixed reporting date, status
vocabulary and current owners. List workbook-specific conventions that belong in .Rules rather
than account Personalisation. Do not edit.
```

Step 2. Open data/Northstar_Workbook_Rules.txt. Copy its lines into .Rules column A with one heading or rule per cell; no data in other columns is required for recognition. Check source preservation, backlog/overdue/rate definitions, S$ display, colours, scope and controlled replacements.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - PLAN:
Review the visible .Rules column A for this Northstar workbook. Identify ambiguous
instructions or conflicts with the actual source and Control. Propose concise corrections,
keeping one idea per cell. Do not edit the source or invent precedence between rules,
preferences and Skills.
```

Step 3. After reviewing any correction, update only .Rules. Add a formula in the next empty column-A cell: ="Reporting date: "&TEXT(Control!B2,"yyyy-mm-dd"). Recalculate and confirm it displays Reporting date:2026-09-30. Copilot reads the formula result on the next prompt; this does not rewrite dashboard values by itself.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - ALLOW EDITING:
Apply only my reviewed .Rules corrections. Keep the sheet visible, one instruction per
column-A cell, and retain the reporting-date formula. Preserve source data, Control and
unrelated sheets.
```

Step 4. Request a Rules_Test summary without restating the formatting rules. Check counts against Control, source references, displayed date/scope, S$ units and proposal wording. The known baseline is120 total,60 backlog,50 overdue and 30/48 on-time Closed.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - ALLOW EDITING:
Create Rules_Test for Northstar Water Services from tblWorkOrders using the visible workbook
.Rules. Include total, backlog, overdue, on-time Closed rate and recorded cost with
formula/source evidence. Show date and All scope. Keep source owners and values unchanged.
```

Step 5. Save As Northstar_Rules_Shared_Copy.xlsx. Open the copy and confirm .Rules is still present and visible in column A; you have not exported your account preferences. If testing a hidden sheet, use only a sandbox copy, hide .Rules, record that hidden rules are not used, then unhide before continuing. Do not claim native rule use when the feature is unavailable.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - CHAT ONLY:
In this copied Northstar workbook, identify the visible .Rules instructions and reporting-date
formula result. Explain which guidance travels with the workbook and which account preferences
do not. Verify Rules_Test against Control without changing records.
```

Step 6. Record the sheet name, visibility, column, formula result, actual output checks and copied-workbook check in data/templates/Customisation_Test_Log.csv. Carry the rules-enabled workbook forward. If a prompt, Skill and rule disagree, ask for clarification and verify the output; no universal precedence is assumed.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - CHAT ONLY:
Compare Personalisation, .Rules and a reusable Skill for Northstar reporting. Place currency
preferences, this workbook's backlog/date rules and the repeatable Pareto workflow in the
right scope. Identify conflicts requiring clarification and the checks a person still must
perform.
```

Sample Prompts

Use the app labelled for each prompt (or adapt it). Name the table and columns, state the output, and always verify the result. Use the linked prompts web page for one-click Copy buttons.

Copy-ready prompts: ../../docs/prompts/index.html#lab-4

#	Purpose	Prompt
1	Scope	State actual source, report date and selected scope before acting.
2	Verify	Explain the source/formula checks and preserve unknowns and original records.

Test It

Check	Expected result
Recognition	Exactly .Rules; visible worksheet; instructions in column A, one idea per cell.
Formula rule	Reporting-date formula recalculates and displays2026-09-30; no source values changed.
Output controls	120 total;60 backlog;50 overdue;30/48 on-time;S$35,827.50 at All scope.
Workbook copy	Visible .Rules travels with the copy; account preferences are not exported.

Checkpoint

If you fell behind, use data/checkpoints/Northstar_Verified_Checkpoint.xlsx and data/checkpoints/Northstar_Verified_Snapshot.docx. Record checkpoint used in Prompt_Log; then perform this lab, rather than claiming the checkpoint as your output.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
Copilot cannot find the source	Use the app file picker to select the actual OneDrive file. A typed local path or a different app chat is not shared context. If needed copy only the verified snapshot into the current app.
A total disagrees with Control	Clear dashboard filters to All, check table extent and duplicate IDs, recalculate, then compare definitions and reporting date. Reconcile before continuing.
The named feature is missing	Confirm the correct assigned account, English display language and app version. Use the stated manual practice route; record feature unavailable. This is not evidence that a native skill ran.

Challenge

Repeat the task for one different site and explain how the filter scope changes the result. Keep the original verified output.

Reflection

Which evidence proves the output is correct, and which decision still needs a person?